

BALENTINE

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INT. LIVING AREA - EVENING

KANNAN (45), sitting on a chair, a bottle of whisky in front of him. He is sipping from a whiskey glass. The living area is dark, except for a candle burning on the table. Kannan is humming an old Hindi song...

KANNAN

(humming) Chandani o meri chandani...

The sound of the main door opening is heard.

SETU

(KANNAN'S SON, WELL-BUILT, HEIGHT 5'8", FOOTBALL PLAYER)

Setu enters, excited about his selection in the junior college football team.

SETU

Hey Papa, Maa kaha hain? Maa?

Kannan looks at him but says nothing, turning back to his whiskey. Setu ignores his behavior as usual.

SETU

Maa, kaha ho? Arey jaldi aao!

Mera selection ho gaya football team main!

Setu looks around for his mother.

SETU

Ye light bhi roz issi time jaati hai...

Papa, Maa kaha hain? Bolo bhi!

Kannan remains silent. After a long pause, he finally speaks.

KANNAN

Gayi teri maa...

SETU

Aapka phir jhagda hua?

SETU - (monologue)

(Setu apne kamre mein khada hai, mutthiyan bheenche, zameen ko ghoor raha hai. Wah gehri saans leta hai, phir upar dekhta hai, jaise kisi se baat kar raha ho jo wahan nahi hai.)

Kyon karte ho aap log aisa? Har. Baar.

Aapko lagta hai mujhe farq nahi padta? Ki main bas apne headphones lagakar sab bhool sakta hoon? Main sab sunta hoon.

Aapki chillane ki awaaz, ek-dusre par ilzaam lagana, maa ki woh halki si kaampti hui awaaz jab woh rona nahi chahti. Papa ka gusse mein darwaaza zor se band karna. Aur main? Main bas... yahan hoon. Fansa hua. Jaise kisi aise khel ka referee jise main khelna hi nahi chahta tha.

Aap hamesha kehte ho, "Ye tumse juda nahi hai, beta." To phir aisa kyon lagta hai ki sab kuch mere hi baare mein hai? Kyon lagta hai ki aap dono ke har taane, har gusse bhare shabd seedhe mujhpar chot kar rahe hain? Jaise main koi rassi hoon, jise aap dono apni taraf kheench rahe ho—gusse mein, naraaz... Aur main? Main bas beech mein khada hoon, khud ko bikharne se bachane ki koshish kar raha hoon.

Main kisi ka paksh nahi leta. Le hi nahi sakta. Kyunki main aap dono se pyaar karta hoon. Lekin kya aapko ab bhi yaad hai ye baat? Kya aapko meri fikr bhi hai? Ya main bas ek parchhayi hoon, koi aisa jise aap ladte hue bhool jaate hain?

(Halki hansii, phir nazar ghooma leta hai.)

Aap hamesha mujhse kehte ho ki main samajhdar banoon. "Bada bano, apni umar ke hisaab se bartav karo." Shayad ab waqt aa gaya hai ki aap bhi wahi karo.

(Wah gehri saans chodta hai, uske kandhe gir jaate hain. Kuch pal chup rehne ke baad, wah jaldi se apni aankhein ponchta hai aur mudkar chala jaata hai.)

Kannan laughs loudly.

KANNAN

(laughing) Ab kabhi nahi hoga...

Setu, frustrated, asks again about his mother.

KANNAN

Ye akhiri tha...

(looks at his whiskey)

SETU

Papa, kya ye jhagda hamesha se tha?

Kannan takes the final sip of his whiskey, places his glass down on the table, and begins to remember his younger days, thinking about the love of his life, Chandani...

KANNAN

(monologue)

Kya ye hamesha aisa tha? Kya ye hamesha se aisa tha? Nahi...

(pauses)

I was in college when I first saw Chandani.

Vo ek samandar ki lehron ki tarah thi... upar niche, upar niche...

She was like a smile of a baby, the smell of a fresh flower.

I fell for her, and she for me.

Vo college ke din... After college, humne shaadi kar li.

Ek do saal sab theek tha... Phir aayi hamari zindagi main hamara beta, Setu.

Uske saath aayi zimedaariyan—uska school, uske sapne.

Aur in sab ke aage main apna sab kuch bhool gaya.

Magar Chandani kuch nahi bhooli...

Uska wohi hasna, apne doston ke saath ghumna phirna.

Mujhe jalan hone lagi... Shayad kuch zyada...

Lagta tha ki bas ya toh use ya apne aap ko khatam kar du...

Par vo pyaar hai mera... Shayad ab main nahi, uska...

Suddenly, the electricity returns. Setu notices a knife on the table, covered in blood. His face tenses, and he anxiously questions his father.

SETU

Ye kya hai, Papa?

KANNAN

Chaaku.

SETU

Par ye khoon kiska hai?

KANNAN

Chandani...

SETU

(in shock)

Papa, Maa kaha hain?

Kannan laughs manically and points to a corner of the house. There lies a body wrapped in a carpet. Setu rushes to it and unwraps the body—it's Chandani. He breaks down, crying. His sorrow quickly turns to rage. He doesn't know what to do. He turns to his father.

Kannan, still intoxicated, chuckles. Setu, in blind rage, grabs the knife, locks his father's body with his legs, and slits his throat. Kannan struggles but ultimately dies.

SETU

Papa... Papa... Papa... (shocked and trembling)

Setu runs towards his mother. At this moment, he transforms into an 8-year-old boy, desperate for love but utterly alone.

SETU

Maa, utho na... Abh Papa nahi ladenge aapse...

Dekho, bilkul chup hain...

Setu looks at his father, then back at his mother. His emotions overwhelm him. He walks over to the couch and lies down in silence.

SETU

(whispering)

Ab Maa Papa kabhi nahi ladenge...

Ab mere dost bhi mujhpe nahi hasenge...

Ab sab accha hoga...

Setu closes his eyes and drifts into sleep.

FADE OUT.